exhausting trips to the bank before she was finally able to draw ₹2,000.

Others were not so fortunate. Newspaper articles started reported increasing numbers of deaths of people who had been waiting endlessly in queues for their money. On 9 January 2017, the West Bengal Chief Minister, Mamata Banerjee, shared a detailed list of 120 persons who had died as a result of demonetization. Appendix 4 contains the tragic details of individuals who died waiting in queues, or committed suicide out of desperation. There were also reports of death of patients who did not receive timely medical treatment because their relatives had no money to pay hospitals or doctors.

The demonetization deaths were, however, denied by the government. Responding to a question on 17 March 2017 in the Lok Sabha on the total number of people who died during the demonetization period and compensation that would be provided to the families of the deceased, the Minister of State for Finance, Arjun Ram Meghwal, said, 'The government has not received any "official report" on deaths during the course of currency exchange and withdrawals following demonetization.'[7]

Middle-class Indians faced tremendous inconvenience as their hard-earned cash was impounded in banks and they had to spend hours trying to withdraw minor amounts. But it was the poorest Indians who suffered the most. Demonetization destroyed both their income and their meagre wealth. Laid off from their contract jobs or unable to sell their produce and forced to take on high cost loans because their own life savings were locked up, the poorest Indians were pushed further into penury and hopelessness.

Some of their stories are narrated below, with grateful thanks to the respective publications who published them.

Many other stories remain untold.

Daily Wage Workers